

"One individual may die for an idea, but that idea will, after his death, incarnate itself in a thousand lives."

SUPREME SOLDIER

Considered by the British as their most resolute and resourceful enemy, this warrior may not have taken to Gandhi's ways, but he was instrumental in the stirring of a new political consciousness

Subhas Chandra Bose

Freedom fighter 1897-1945

■ By Sugata Bose

In one respect," Christopher Bayly and Tim Harper write of the war situation in 1943, "the British had much to fear. Subhas Chandra Bose, their most resolute and resourceful Indian enemy, was on the move." Bose had boarded a German U-boat at Kiel on February 8, 1943, on a perilous voyage across half the globe to Southeast Asia. "There is a certain amount of risk undoubtedly in this undertaking," Bose had written to the then German foreign minister Joachim von Ribbentrop on December 5, 1942, "but so is there in every undertaking. I believe in my destiny and I therefore believe that this endeavour will succeed." After a 90-day journey—that included a transfer in a rubber raft from a German to a Japanese submarine in the Indian Ocean—Bose arrived in Sabang on the island of Sumatra. From there he flew to Tokyo and back to Singapore where he took over the leadership of the Indian National Army on July 4-5, 1943.

Yet when the Battle of Britain was raging over the skies of London, the colonial masters had their most uncompromising opponent safely behind bars in the Presidency Jail of Calcutta. On November 29, 1940, he launched a fast unto death in prison. "Nobody can lose through suffering and sacrifice," he had written on



Bose (seated)